male whereas in female it is used to cover vagina and cervix just before coitus so as to prevent the entry of ejaculated semen into the female reproductive tract. This can prevent conception. Condoms should be discarded after a single use. Condom also safeguards the user from AIDS and STDs. Condoms are made of polyurethane, latex and lambskin.

Diaphragms, cervical caps and vaults are made of rubber and are inserted into the female reproductive tract to cover the cervix before coitus in order to prevent the sperms from entering the uterus.

c. Hormonal barrier

It prevents the ovaries from releasing the ova and thickens the cervical fluid which keeps the sperm away from ovum.

Oral contraceptives — Pills are used to prevent ovulation by inhibiting the secretion of FSH and LH hormones. A combined pill is the most commonly used birth control pill. It contains synthetic progesterone and estrogen hormones. **Saheli,** contraceptive pill by Central Drug Research Institute (CDRI) in Lucknow, India contains a non-steroidal preparation called **Centchroman**.

d. Intrauterine Devices (IUDs)

Intrauterine devices are inserted by medical experts in the uterus through the vagina. These devices are available as copper releasing IUDs, hormone releasing IUDs and non-medicated IUDs. IUDs increase phagocytosis of sperm within the uterus. IUDs are the ideal contraceptives for females who want to delay pregnancy. It is one of the popular methods of contraception in India and has a success rate of 95 to 99%.

Copper releasing IUDs differ from each other by the amount of copper. Copper IUDs such as **Cu T-380 A, Nova T, Cu 7, Cu T 380 Ag, Multiload 375, etc.** release free copper and copper salts into the uterus and suppress sperm motility. They can remain in the uterus for five to ten years.

Hormone-releasing IUDs such as **Progestasert and LNG – 20** are often called as intrauterine systems (IUS). They increase the viscosity of the cervical mucus and thereby prevent sperms from entering the cervix.

Non-medicated IUDs are made of plastic or stainless steel. Lippes loop is a double S-shaped plastic device.

3. Permanent birth control methods are adopted by the individuals who do not want to have any more children.

Surgical sterilisation methods are the permanent contraception methods advised for male and female partners to prevent any more pregnancies. It blocks the transport of the gametes and prevents conception. **Tubectomy** is the surgical sterilisation in women. In this procedure, a small portion of both fallopian tubes are cut and tied up through a small incision in the abdomen or through vagina. This prevents fertilization as well as the entry of the egg into the uterus. **Vasectomy** is the surgical procedure for male sterilisation. In this procedure, both vas deferens are cut and tied through a small incision on the scrotum to prevent the entry of sperm into the urethra. Vasectomy prevents sperm from heading off to penis as the discharge has no sperms in it.

3.5. Medical termination of pregnancy (MTP)

Medical method of abortion is a voluntary or intentional termination of pregnancy in a non-surgical or non-invasive way. Early medical termination is extremely safe upto 12 weeks (the first trimester) of

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